The Indian leadership did not always give China the benefit of the doubt at US expense, even though Washington might not have seen it that way. Bajpai, for instance, acknowledged conciliatory American steps. The government also recognized that Beijing could be difficult—one reason Delhi, for example, asked its representative not to vote to include it in UN talks on Korea.[146] And then there was the Chinese action that raised doubts in—and had serious implications for—Delhi: its move into Tibet in October 1950.

Tibet: Lost by Default? (1950–1951)

While there had been debate in India about the timing and nature of a Chinese takeover of Tibet,[147] the invasion itself was not unexpected. A year before, in September 1949, Nehru had predicted that China would invade Tibet, possibly within the year, bringing it to India's doorstep.[148] Many were aware of the consequences. Even Panikkar noted it would bring unprecedented "pressures" on India, though he did not think China would have the ability to intervene directly in India for another decade.[149] Over the next year, Indian officials had continued to expect matters to "come to a head" in Tibet.[150] They tried to delay this eventuality to "gain time for India" and keep the Chinese and communist influence at bay.[151]

Indian policymakers had crystallized their Tibet policy and conveyed it to American officials by January 1950. It basically involved "leav[ing] the matter alone." K. P. S. Menon worried about China exporting communism via Tibet when they took over and about the status of the India-Tibet boundary.[152] But he told the American political counselor that India would not take the initiative on Tibet with China. If Beijing accepted Tibetan autonomy, Delhi would recognize Chinese authority over Tibet. In the meantime, India would continue and possibly expedite its sale of small arms to Tibet and even train Tibetan officers, but it would not welcome the establishment of a Tibetan liaison office in India. Menon also emphasized that India would not take military action if China attacked Tibet.[153] Delhi also resisted Anglo-American pressure to increase aid to Tibet. Finally, Menon discouraged American involvement—and particularly any discussions in Delhi—on the grounds that it would convince Beijing of a US-India anti-China conspiracy. This could expedite a Chinese takeover of Tibet.[154]